

Personal Profile

My name is Dylan, and I am a Doctoral candidate in Political Science at the Institute for Social Sciences, University of Oldenburg. My research focuses on the role of language in politics, particularly in the context of references to social groups. I investigate how politicians communicate and construct in parliament and on social media. Specifically, my work examines party politics and political groups. To explore this interaction, I analyze legislative speeches and images posted online by political elites, employing innovative methods from computational social science (NLP and Computer Vision).

Education

University of Oldenburg

PhD in Political Science

- Supervisor: Prof. Marius Sältzer

Oldenburg, Germany

August 2025 - Ongoing

University of Zurich

MA in Political Science, Minor Methods-Data-Society (Grade: 5.8)

- Thesis: The mismatch between citizens perceived bias and actual bias in news coverage (Grade: 6.0)
- Supervisor: Prof. Dr. Karsten Donnay

Zurich, Switzerland

August 2021 - July 2023

University of Mannheim

BA in Political Science, Minor Public Law (Grade: 1.6)

- Thesis: Affective Polarization at German State Elections, 1990 - 2020 (Grade: 1.0)
- Supervisor: Prof. Dr. Rüdiger Schmitt-Beck

Mannheim, Germany

August 2017 - July 2021

Work Experience

ERC Project: "MULTIREP"

Research Assistant

- PI: Assoz. Prof. Christopher Wratil
- Developed survey questionnaires with innovative formats
- Conducted sentiment and content analysis of open-ended survey responses using NLP approaches
- Assisted in qualitative fieldwork, including focus group construction
- Built LLM infrastructure with Azure for the project

University of Vienna, Austria

October 2023 - July 2025

Project: "DigiVox"

Student Research Assistant

- PI: Prof. Dr. Karsten Donnay, Prof. Dr. Eszter Hargittai & Prof. Dr. Lucas Leemann
- Designed and implemented the first wave of a longitudinal survey on Qualtrics
- Supervised survey administration
- Conducted data wrangling and analysis of survey data

University of Zurich, Switzerland

March 2022 - July 2023

Project: "The Populist Challenge in Parliament"

Student Research Assistant

- PI: Prof. Dr. Jochen Müller
- Webscraped Wikipedia pages of East German state parliaments
- Collected demographic data on every parliamentarian from 1990 to 2020
- Constructed a usable dataset for further research

Humboldt University Berlin,
Germany

September 2021 - December 2021

Project: "Influence of social media on political reporting"

Student Research Assistant

- PI: Dr. Corinna Oschatz & Prof. Dr. Sebastian Stier
- Developed a web crawler and parser for twelve German media outlets
- Built a server-based database
- Supervised technical processes
- Cleaned and wrangled data for analysis

GESIS Cologne, Germany

June 2021 - December 2021

Project: “Experiences of Everyday Racism and Media-Mediated Racism in the (Political) Public Sphere”

MZES Mannheim, Germany

Student Research Assistant

November 2020 - February 2021

- PI: Prof. Dr. Marius Sältzer
- Assisted in designing a coding scheme for tweets
- Contributed to developing a semi-supervised topic model by building a dictionary
- Hand-coded hatspeech tweets

Project: “The Populist Challenge in Parliament”

MZES Mannheim, Germany

Student Research Assistant

April 2020 - July 2021

- PI: Prof. Dr. Christian Stecker
- Webscraped all German state parliament databases to collect “Kleine Anfragen”
- Administered and supervised a custom database
- Performed data manipulation
- Supported the analysis of the Kommunalwahlkompass with a Shiny App

Publications

2025 - **Paltra, Dylan**; Sältzer, Marius; Stecker, Christian: *Affective States: Cultural and Affective Polarization in a Multilevel-Multiparty System. Political Behavior*. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11109-025-10088-6>

2024 - Oschatz, Corinna; Gil-Lopez, Theresa; **Paltra, Dylan**; Stier, Sebastian; Schultz, Tanjev: *Social media posts as source for political news coverage inside and outside election campaigns: Examining effects on deliberative news media quality. Journalism, 25(8), 1638-1656.* <https://doi.org/10.1177/14648849241231698>

Work in Progress:

2026 - **Paltra**; Diener; Kroeber: *The agency of women in political debates.*

2026 - **Paltra**; Sältzer; Wonka: *Relational Group Frames in Political Debates.*

2026 - **Paltra**: *Sitting On The Fence: Examining intra-party heterogeneity in group appeals.*

2024 - Schmidt; **Paltra**; Masch; Sältzer: *Narcissistic Politicians Post More Self-Promotional Images on Social Media. Under Review*

2024 - **Paltra**; Cappellina; Wratil; Fernezelyi; Ó Hannracháin: *The Citizens’ Concept of Representation: Evidence from an Open-Ended Questions Survey.*

2024 - Versteegen; **Paltra**; Wratil: *The Consequences of Experiencing Political Representation: From Emotions to Actions.*

2023 - **Paltra**; Donnay: *More Diverse Than They Think: Citizens’ (Mis)perceptions of Diversity in Their News Consumption*

Conferences and Workshops

2026 - Relational Group Frames in Political Debates *EPSS, Belfast, Northern Ireland.*

2026 - The agency of women in political debates *ECPG, Newcastle upon Tyne, Great Britain.*

2026 - The agency of women in political debates *COMPTExT, Birmingham, Great Britain.*

2026 - How politicians objectify women in the political discourse *DVPW Methods, Hannover, Germany.*

2025 - How the personal can bridge gaps: Investigating the interplay between personalization and out-group representation. *DVPW Parliaments, Kiel, Germany.*

2025 - The Citizens’ Concept of Representation: Evidence from an Open-Ended Questions Survey. *COMPTExT Conference, Vienna, Austria.*

2023 - Measuring the mismatch between citizens’ perceived and actual bias in news coverage. *EPSA Conference, Glasgow, Scotland.*

2023 - Talking about the Weather - Explaining Regional Salience of Climate Change across Time in the German States with Marius Sältzer. *Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung Workshop, Remote.*

2021 - Candidates and Fringe Candidates on Social Media. *Digital Democracy Workshop, Zurich, Switzerland.*

2021 - Affective Polarization Around the World: Measurement, Causes and Consequences. *ECPR Workshop, Remote.*

Additional Training

2024 - ECPR Summer School of the Standing Group on Parliaments. *Summer School, Frankfurt, Germany.*

2024 - ICPSR at University of Michigan. *Summer School, Ann Arbor, USA.*

2023 - Summer Institute in Computational Social Science. *Summer School, Munich, Germany.*

Programming

R baseR, RSelenium, rvest, seededlda, STM, quanteda, spacyR, Stan
Python Pandas, NumPy, TensorFlow, Beautiful Soup
Miscellaneous SQL, Linux, Shell (Bash), HPC, JavaScript, $\text{\LaTeX}$ (Overleaf/R Markdown), HPC, Git, Qualtrics, Microsoft Office.

Languages

German Native
English Professional proficiency
Spanish Basic
Swedish Basic

References

Upon request.